

After I got over the initial embarrassment of being categorized as part of the poor population by her husband, I wondered if there was a grain of truth to his statement. While I knew it wasn't only the poor who used coupons, I did approach the writing of this book with a similar misconception—that it might be those who were either raised in a lower income household or struggling to live on a stringent budget that would be most likely to use them.

It turns out we were both wrong. According to the results of a 2009 survey released by the Nielsen Company, it is actually the opposite; the more affluent consumers—those making \$70,000 or more annually—use coupons the most frequently. In fact, households with incomes of \$100,000 or more were the primary drivers of coupon growth in 2009. Other serious users included those from large households and consumers living in affluent suburban or “comfortable country areas” on the fringes of larger cities. Groups least likely to use them were low-income, one-member households, male-only head of households, African-Americans, Hispanic consumers, and those living in rural or struggling urban areas.

One explanation for this disparity is the trend relating to newspaper readership. According to New York-based Scarborough Research, it is the well-educated and higher income households that buy and read newspapers more than others, and the newspaper remains the key vehicle for delivering coupons. Additionally, promotions are generally targeted in areas with more affluent consumers.

So, does that mean that coupon users are a smarter bunch of people? For the purpose of categorization, in a word—yes. Or, at least we'd like to think